

PHYS851 Notes

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1 Review of QFT I

We have 2 problems with quantum mechanics. The first is Lorentz invariance, quantum mechanics is not relativistic, and it is sort of “hard coded” into QM that we do not obey relativity. This is because relativity treats space and time on equal footing, we can rotate x into t via a boost. However, quantum mechanics treats x and t very differently, x is an operator, we can compute the expected location of things by taking an expectation value of position, $\langle x \rangle$. On the other hand, t is a label, not an operator. This difference between space and time is baked into quantum mechanics. The second problem is that we have superluminal travel, which according to relativity, removes causality from the theory, which is a massive problem. Explicitly:

$$\langle x_f | e^{-iHt} | x_i \rangle \neq 0 \quad \forall x_f, t > 0$$

These are our two reasons for requiring drastic changes to the quantum mechanics paradigm.

The approach we take to remedying these problems is to look at a classical theory in which space and time are taken as labels, classical electromagnetism. If we do this, we accidentally end up solving the second problem! We can first pick what we are describing as a function of space and time, and then we can quantize the theory to make it quantum mechanical. In classical mechanics, we have many examples of things that can be functions of x and t , such as potentials, electric fields, the stress-energy tensor, etc. Thus we have scalars, vectors, tensors, that are all functions of space and time. In field theory, we systematize this construction. Why do we like vectors? Because they transform nicely under rotations. In the relativistic case, we need things that transform nicely under rotations *and boosts*. What do we mean by “nice” here? Looking at this mathematically, rotations form the group $SO(3)$, and the addition of boosts constructs the group $SO(3,1)$ ¹. This group has some special properties, the first of which is that we can write it as two rotation groups:

$$SO(3,1) = SO(3) \otimes SO(3)$$

That is, we can write our Lorentz group elements in terms of objects from both rotation groups:

$$R_{x,y,z} \pm iK_{x,y,z} \in SO(3,1)$$

Let us now consider a single rotation group. What does it mean to be nice under $SO(3)$ (sometimes written as $SU(2)$). What we mean intuitively is that we multiply a vector position by a rotation matrix:

$$\mathbf{x}' = R\mathbf{x}$$

or, in index notation:

$$x'_a = R_{ab}x_b$$

This is fundamentally what we mean when we say that things behave “nicely” under rotations. However, the key point is that the matrices R_{ab} are very specific matrices, they must be representations of the rotation group.

Simple examples can show that the order of rotations matter, the rotation matrices do not commute:

$$R_x(\theta_1) R_y(\theta_2) \neq R_y(\theta_2) R_x(\theta_1)$$

¹Note that we do not write $SO(4)$, because we have the restriction on $\mathbf{x}^2 - t^2$, the minus sign here matters

Any rotation matrices that we define must satisfy the infinite number of commutation constraints that we expect from 3 dimensional intuition. We can simplify this down to a finite number of constraints. First, we note that we can define any rotation as:

$$R = e^{i\theta_j \tau_j}$$

Where τ_j is a Hermitian matrix, since rotations must be length preserving, and $j \in x, y, z$. With this representation of rotations, the constraints on rotations boil down to the statement:

$$[\tau_j, \tau_k] = i\epsilon_{jkl}\tau_l$$

In other words, if we want an $N \times N$ representation of the rotations, we need 3 $N \times N$ matrices that satisfy this condition.

Note that for non-rotation groups, the only difference is that instead of the Levi-Civita symbol, we have some other number, generally known as the structure constant:

$$[\tau_j, \tau_k] = if_{jkl}\tau_l$$

Returning to rotations in particular, it turns out that there is 1 solution, for all N . What does this mean for us? For $N = 1$, $\tau_i = 0$, and we have a solution. For $N = 3$, we recover vectors, and for $N = 5$ we recover anti-symmetric matrices. Classically, we recover the odd N solutions.

What about even N ? For $N = 2$, we find that $\tau = \sigma$, the Pauli matrices. Why did we miss this in classical mechanics? It's because rotations of 360 degrees using the Paulis produces a minus sign, rather than the identity. In the quantum mechanical case, the minus sign doesn't matter, since we only care about the modulus of the wavefunction.

Now let us look back at the Lorentz group, which we said was composed of two rotation groups, generally labelled by left and right rotation groups:

$$SO(3,1) = SU(2)_L \otimes SU(2)_R$$

For every object we construct, we have to know how it transforms under each rotation group, which we generally label by the maximum t_z eigenvalue for each of the groups. For example, we could have an object be a scalar under each group, which we label as $(0,0)$. We could have it be a scalar under one group, but a fermion under the other:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Left fermions} &\rightarrow \left(\frac{1}{2}, 0\right) \\ \text{Right fermions} &\rightarrow \left(0, \frac{1}{2}\right) \end{aligned}$$

We could also have a fermion under both groups, which turns out to be a vector:

$$\text{Vector} \rightarrow \left(\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}\right)$$

We can keep going for all cases, and it's up to experiment to tell us which ones we have discovered in reality.

We have now categorized every object that we can write down that correctly transforms under the symmetry group that we care about. Note that nothing we have done so far is quantum, so let

us now introduce it. First, we must determine which “language” to use. Classically, we have two formalisms, Lagrangian/Hamiltonian mechanics and via equations of motion, such as Newton’s Laws or Maxwell’s equations.

It turns out that the Lagrangian/Hamiltonian formalism is much easier to work with. Consider computing something of the form

$$\langle x_f | e^{-iHt} | x_i \rangle$$

The way to compute this is to sum up the possible paths by which our particle can propagate:

$$\begin{aligned} \langle x_f | e^{-iHt} | x_i \rangle &= \sum_{\text{all paths}} e^{i\phi} \\ &= \int dx_{\text{all paths}} e^{iS} \end{aligned}$$

Where S is the action. When we are doing Lagrangian mechanics classically, we are really just doing this and taking the most probable path as the classical trajectory (principle of least action). Quantum mechanically, we have to take into account the other paths. For this reason, Lagrangians and Hamiltonians are more natural. There are also some other benefits, such as the fact that if $\mathcal{L}$ has a symmetry, the theory described by this $\mathcal{L}$ also has that symmetry.

To quantize a theory, recall that we impose the canonical commutation relations:

$$[q, p] = i\hbar$$

Note that this is natural in the case of the Lagrangian formalism, since $\mathcal{L}$ is a function of q and $\dot{q}$. In the case of electromagnetism, $q = A_\mu$, in the case of scalar field theories, $q = \phi$, in the case of gravity $q = h_{\mu\nu}$, etc.

Recall that the classical EM Lagrangian is given by

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{EM}} = -\frac{1}{4} F^{\mu\nu} F_{\mu\nu}$$

Where $F^{\mu\nu} = \partial^\mu A^\nu - \partial^\nu A^\mu$. To quantize this theory, we first find that $p_\mu = \dot{A}_\mu$, and therefore we impose the commutation relations²:

$$[A_\mu(x), \dot{A}_\nu(y)] = -i\delta^3(x-y)g_{\mu\nu}$$

If we do this, we find that it is most natural to define creation and annihilation operators:

$$a, a^\dagger \sim x \pm ip$$

It turns out that we can express these in terms of Fourier transforms:

$$\phi = \int \frac{d\mathbf{p}}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\omega}} (a_{\mathbf{p}} e^{-ip \cdot x} + a_{\mathbf{p}}^\dagger e^{ip \cdot x})$$

Where the creation and annihilation operators obey the commutation relations:

$$[a_{\mathbf{p}}, a_{\mathbf{p}}^\dagger] = (2\pi)^3 \delta^3(\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{q})$$

²Note that we are using the $(+, -, -, -)$ metric convention.

Note that in the case of a vector particle, we would write the same Fourier expansion, just with additional polarization vectors:

$$A_\mu = \int \frac{d\mathbf{p}}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\omega}} \sum_s \left(\varepsilon_{s,\mu} a_{\mathbf{p}} e^{-ip \cdot x} + \varepsilon_{s,\mu}^\dagger a_{\mathbf{p}}^\dagger e^{ip \cdot x} \right)$$

For a fermion:

$$\psi_\alpha = \int \frac{d\mathbf{p}}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{1}{\sqrt{2\omega}} \sum_s \left(u_\alpha^s a_{\mathbf{p}} e^{-ip \cdot x} + v_\alpha^s a_{\mathbf{p}}^\dagger e^{ip \cdot x} \right)$$

If we look at the free scalar Lagrangian, we have:

$$\mathcal{L} = \frac{1}{2} (\partial_\mu \phi)^2 - \frac{1}{2} m^2 \phi^2$$

which reproduces the expected relation $\omega^2 = p^2 + m^2$. We can do the same thing for all sorts of more complicated particles, just making sure that we have the correct physical interpretations.

At long last, we have free particles, so how do we introduce interactions? We go into the interaction picture, which is a mix of the Schrodinger (states evolve in time) and Heisenberg (operators evolve in time) pictures. In the interaction picture, we separate our Hamiltonian into a free and interaction Hamiltonian:

$$H = H_{\text{free}} + h_{\text{interaction}}$$

We then define states and operators:

$$\begin{aligned} |\psi_I\rangle &= e^{iH_{\text{free}}t} |\psi_S\rangle \\ O_I &= e^{iH_{\text{free}}t} O_S e^{-iH_{\text{free}}t} \end{aligned}$$

The time evolution of our states can be computed:

$$|\psi_I(t)\rangle = T\{e^{-iH_{\text{int}}t}\} |\psi_I(0)\rangle$$

Where T denotes a time order product. Many observables can be written in the form:

$$\langle 0|T\{O_1(x_1) O_2(x_2) O_3(x_3) \dots e^{-iH_{\text{free}}t}\}|0\rangle$$

This allows us to compute things like scattering amplitudes and cross sections. Thus we have covered (very briefly) the content of QFT I.

What will we cover in QFT II? Broadly speaking:

1. Renormalization (Perturbation theory $\rightarrow$ loop diagrams $\rightarrow$ RG)
2. Non-Abelian Gauge theories (Spin 1 charged particles, renormalization of gauge theories)
3. Path Integrals
4. Miscellaneous Topics